DANIEL OVERBECK

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EMPLOYMENT

Assistant Professor of Economics (tenure-track) 2025 -
National University of Singapore (Lee Kuan Yew School of Public Policy)

EDUCATION

University of Mannheim - Economics, Ph.D. 2025

University of Bonn - Economics, M.Sc. 2019

University of Heidelberg - Economics, B.Sc. 2017

RESEARCH FIELDS

Public Economics, Development Economics

PUBLICATIONS

"The (fiscal) Dividend of Infrastructure: Roads and Revenues in Rwanda", with Abdou Musonera (U Rwanda) and Aimable Nsabimana (World Bank)
***Journal of Public Economics*, Volume 259, July 2026, 105676**

This paper shows that infrastructure investments enhance local tax outcomes. Drawing on a novel dataset combining information on the location and timing of all road upgrades in Rwanda with 12 years of administrative tax and census records, we estimate large and significant increases in tax revenues in municipalities near to upgraded roads. These effects are driven by firm entry as well as land value appreciation, captured through taxes on rental income at the local level. Finally, we show that while the additional revenues do not fully recover the central government's initial investment, local municipalities' revenues more than double within five years.

"Place-based policies, structural change and female labor: Evidence from India's Special Economic Zones", with Johannes Gallé (MCC Berlin), Nadine Riedel (U Münster) and Tobias Seidel (U Duisburg-Essen)
***Journal of Public Economics*, Volume 240, December 2024, 105259**

This paper quantifies the local economic impact of Special Economic Zones (SEZs) that were established in India between 2005-2013. Based on a novel data set that combines census data on the universe of Indian firms with georeferenced data on SEZs, we find that SEZs increased manufacturing and service employment with positive spillover effects up to 10km. This employment gain was paralleled by a decline in local agricultural employment, in particular of women, suggesting that the policy contributed to structural change. We find no evidence for heterogeneous effects between privately and publicly run SEZs or zones with different industry denominations.

WORKING PAPERS

"Bargaining Over Taxes", with Eliya Lungu (Zambia Revenue Authority)
CESifo Working Paper 12172

We show that bargaining over taxes constitutes a central feature of tax compliance in low state capacity environments. Using administrative records from Zambia, we document systematic deviations from predictions of standard models

of tax compliance. Taxpayers bunch sharply in dominated regions above tax schedule discontinuities and at round-number payments. These patterns are inconsistent with standard models, but can be explained by bargaining between tax collectors and taxpayers, for which we provide additional evidence from our own taxpayer survey. Finally, we show that allowing for bargaining in standard models of tax compliance leads to Pareto-improvements if state capacity is sufficiently low.

"Carbon Taxation and Firm Behavior in Emerging Economies: Evidence from South Africa", with Johannes Gallé (MCC Berlin), Rodrigo Oliveira (UNU-WIDER), Nadine Riedel (U Münster) and Edson Severnini (Boston College)
NBER Working Paper 34406

This paper provides the first comprehensive evidence on how firms in an emerging economy respond to carbon taxation in the context of an early-phase policy, highlighting how firms adjust when incentives are modest but signals about future regulation are strong. We study the announcement and early implementation of South Africa's 2019 carbon tax using detailed administrative firm-level data from 2011-2021. Employing a matched difference - in- differences design and event-study models, we trace dynamic firm responses. Contrary to concerns that carbon taxes might hinder growth or employment, we find no negative effects on firm performance or jobs. Leveraging variation in firms' exposure to the tax through temporary tax-free allowances, we find that firms facing higher effective tax rates increased sales, employment, capital, and capital depreciation in anticipation of the policy, reflecting resolution of regulatory uncertainty and adjustments to mitigate stranded asset risks. While we detect no measurable reduction in emissions – likely due to anticipatory behavior—the results show that early – phase carbon pricing can shape firm behavior without harming economic outcomes, even in low- and middle-income settings.

"Tax Administration and Firm Performance: Evidence from VAT Refund Delays", with Kwabena Adu-Ababio (UNU-WIDER) and Eliya Lungu (Zambia Revenue Authority)
UNU-WIDER Working Paper 107/2026

This paper shows how weak tax administration leads to economic costs for firms in developing countries. We study the case of VAT refund processing in Zambia, where, as we document in a novel dataset, firms wait 700 days for reimbursement on aver- age. Linking our dataset to the universe of tax returns at the firm level, we establish several stylized facts on the pitfalls of refund processing and estimate the economic costs of refund delays for firms. To do so, we rely on an instrumental-variable approach which exploits plausibly exogenous variation in administrative congestion at the time of claiming. The results show that prolonged refund delays significantly reduce firms' sales, taxable purchases, profits, investment, and employment, consistent with firms facing binding working-capital constraints while awaiting reimbursement. These findings suggest that the effectiveness of tax systems depends not only on statutory design but also on the capacity of tax administrations to implement them.

"Taxing FDI in a developing economy: the case of informality"

This paper introduces a new model which captures the effect of foreign direct investment (FDI) on a developing economy with an informal sector. The informal sector evolves endogenously as economic agents choose between working and setting up a firm and whether to do so formally or informally. FDI induces a uniform increase in labor costs but heterogenous productivity increases for domestic formal firms. Accordingly, some of these firms may opt for informality with increased FDI. This reduction in the domestic tax base may offset any revenue gains from additional FDI. It is shown that the revenue-neutral tax rate on FDI is decreasing in the government's efficiency in screening tax avoidance. Empirical evidence from panel data supports both key theoretical results.

MEDIA AND POLICY OUTREACH

"Do paved roads pay for themselves? Evidence from Rwanda", *VoxDev Column, August 2026*

"The Zambia Revenue Authority VAT panel", *WIDER Technical Note 1/2026, February 2026*

"How do small firms respond to turnover taxes?", *IGC Policy Brief, August 2025*

"How can informal interactions and bargaining affect tax compliance and enforcement?", *Tax for Growth, IGC Online Blog, December 2024*

"Place-based policy in India: How Special Economic Zones promoted structural change and women's employment", *VoxDev Column, December 2024*

"Place-based policy, Structural Change And Female Labor", *Faculti Interview, November 2023*

EXTERNAL GRANTS & SCHOLARSHIPS

£10,000 from International Growth Center, **P.I. and sole applicant** 2023/2024
(for survey + experiment in Zambia)

£2,000 from International Growth Center, **P.I. and sole applicant** 2024/2025
(for collaboration with the Rwanda Revenue Authority)

$10,000 from UNU-WIDER, **Co P.I.** 2023/2024
(for project: "Carbon Taxation in Emerging Economies")

Full scholarship for PhD coursework from German Research Foundation (DFG) 2019-2021

CONFERENCES & INVITED SEMINARS

2026 -2027 (incl. scheduled)
CESifo Area Conference on Public Economics (Munich), Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (Cornell), Rethinking fiscal policies in the global South (LSE), Jobs and Development Conference (Hong Kong), Monash University Malaysia (invited), University of Mainz (invited), Goethe University Frankfurt (invited), University of Tübingen (invited), National Taiwan University (invited), Peking University (invited)

2025
Paris School of Economics (invited), International Monetary Fund (invited, online), Wageningen University – Development Group (invited), National University of Singapore (invited), University of Stuttgart (invited), IGC Tax for Growth Webinar, CESifo Area Conference on Public Economics (Munich), ZEW Public Finance Conference (Mannheim), German Development Conference (Frankfurt), Taxing Smarter Conference (Lusaka)

2024
Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (Boston), National Tax Association Conference (Detroit), German Development Economics Conference (Hannover), ZEW Public Finance Conference (Mannheim), Annual Congress of the IIPF (Prague), Mannheim Taxation Conference (Mannheim), University of Mannheim, Walter Eucken Institut Freiburg (invited), University of Mainz (invited), University of Passau (invited)

2023
University of Zambia (invited), University of Mannheim, ifo Institute Munich, International Conference on Empirical Economics (Penn State University at Altoona), Annual Congress of the EEA (Barcelona), FHM+ Workshop (Frankfurt), South-Asia Institute/Heidelberg University (invited)

2022
CEPR/STEG Theme 1 workshop, Institute for Fiscal Studies (invited), Annual Congress of the IIPF (Linz), Annual Conference of the ETSG (Groningen), RGS Doctoral Conference (Bochum), University of Mannheim, EVS-online PhD Seminar, Mannheim-Frankfurt PhD Conference (Frankfurt)

2016-2021
12th Annual Conference on Economic Growth and Development (New Delhi), University of Mannheim

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Refereeing: Journal of Economic Behaviour and Organization, International Tax and Public Finance, Review of World Economics, Applied Economics, Palgrave books

Workshop/Seminar Organization: 7th FHM Workshop in Development Economics (Mannheim, October 2024); Research Connect Seminar at NUS (2025 onwards)

Misc.: PhD Examiner; Master of Public Policy Admission Committee at NUS

TEACHING

NUS - Coding for Public Policy using R (MPP), Instructor	Spring 2026
NUS - Financial Management for Public Organizations (MPP), Instructor	Fall 2025
University of Mannheim - Public Finance (B.Sc.), TA and subst. instructor	Spring 2023, 2024
DHBW Karlsruhe - Philisophy of Science (B.A.), Instructor	2023-
University of Mannheim - Econometrics (B.Sc.), TA	Spring 2021, 2022
University of Bonn - Statistics (B.Sc.), TA	Winter 2018
University of Heidelberg - Mathematics for Economists (B.Sc.), TA	Winter 2014, 2015

RESEARCH ASSISTANCE

University of Bonn - RA for Moritz Schularick	2019
University of Heidelberg - RA for Axel Dreher	2015, 2016

NON-ACADEMIC PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Federal Ministry for Economic Cooperation and Development, Bonn, Germany - Internship	May-Jul 2017
Indo-German Chamber of Commerce, Pune, India - Internship	Oct 2016-Feb 2017

OTHER

Software: STATA, R, Matlab, Github
Languages: German (native), English (fluent), French (conversational, B1)
Personal: Married, two kids (born February 2019 and August 2024)

ACADEMIC REFERENCES

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